

Paragon

Linden Brochu

Chapter 1 New recruits

— Prisoners, form ranks !

There he stood, the Queen's killer. From what I heard in the wagon, he killed a royal knight and the queen at a banquet.

— From today onward, you populace join the anti monster battalion. For those who received the death sentence, welcome to hell. You are going to the front line in 2 hours.

I am sentenced to death. So, this is my end, huh? Tonight I will be delivered.

— As the most ancient prisoner, my work here consists of making you fight for another day.

Oh, was he? I killed a child because I was hungry. I don't deserve to live.

— Rally up, the guards will give your equipment.

The guards looked at me with disgust in their eyes - as they should.

I got a gambeson with claw marks on the neck. I guess getting fresh gear is out the question for prisoners. The bastards also gave me a one-handed mace. I never used weapons before. What do they expect me to do with that?

The area was nearly empty. Apart from the soldiers and a few veteran prisoners, there were only a couple of tents.

— So Sir Queen killer, started one who got arrested for theft, where is the rest of the battalion?

— What rest of the battalion? We are all. The others died in the last monster's assault.

In the corner of my vision, I spotted my carriage's neighbour. Poor him. Couldn't pay his taxes. Now he has got a 2-year contract here. The guards gave him a crossbow.

— You rat ! I ain't dying here for your ass, said the thief.

The thief went toward my carriage neighbour and grabbed his crossbow. He was about to shoot a guard when the Queen's killer grabbed him by the neck, then threw him to the ground.

— I don't care what your crime was, you come to the front with us starting today.

The thief's hair went up on his arms.

As the calm crawled back into the encampment, a lone rider, with arrows in his spine, came crashing down a few metres before me. I went to try to rescue him.

Did the battalion get regular soldiers too? I took off his helmet. The poor man was dead; he wouldn't need it anymore.

With the metal protection in my hand, I was horrified. This guard . . . was escorting us here half an hour ago.

As I stood there, I heard it. The cry of a child. It had the same cries as the one I killed.

My leg hardened. My heart raced. Chills ran up my spine.

From behind a tree, I could see its nails. Longer than my mace. How could it be?

I quickly equipped the dead guard's helmet. All of this only to see its eyes, peaking behind the same tree.

— Come fight me !

The thing jumped. It leaped ten metres onto my shoulder without a sweat before I could even give a swing. It was skinny, without muscles. However, it was unbearably heavy. My leg instantly flinched when it got on me.

My carriage neighbour shot a bolt in his head. No blood came out. The creature didn't seem to bother either. It dragged its claws across my gambeson. I couldn't do anything - I was paralyzed.

I heard arrows whistling. I gave a quick glance at my carriage neighbour only to see him with one in his heart. Unhappy that I diverted my gaze, the thing started to cry once again. Please, it said I'm hungry.

The sound it made made me feel like vomiting.

This was my moment to die. It was sooner than expected, at least I did try to fight. As I was about to close my eyes, a sword penetrated through the thing's chest.

— Be gone, Daemon !

My saviour swung the creature on an orc with a bow. He dragged me into the mud until I was out of reach of the monsters.

My arms and legs were shaking like crazy. I was about to die. Why does my body try to fight that thing? I gripped my mace so hard that my hand was numb and bloody.

— Wake up ! Wake up !

I finally recognized the prisoner that saved me, the Queen's killer. I tried to speak, but no sound came.

He looked at me as if he wanted to say something. His mouth opened slightly, then closed again.

Instead, he hurried back to my carriage's neighbour. I watched him kneel. The scene froze for several seconds. When he returned, the body in his arms, his grim look told me everything.

— Why did you save me? I killed a child !

I said it. Now everybody knew.

— And you feel guilty, am I right?

— Of course.

— Then, don't pay for your crime by your death. Pay by your life. Each monster that you slay is one less that could ravage our land and kill the children. If you really feel guilty, then make sure it does not happen again, by living.

— I don't want to die.

— You don't have to. You survived the hardest part.

I could hold back my tears any longer. They ran wild on my cheeks. Saving people ... through living?

— I'll try.

By the time I wiped my eyes, the Queen's killer was already running back to battle.